

CAD FORUM
**WHATEVER HAPPENED TO “VALUE DEBATE”?:
REFLECTIONS ON NON-POLICY DEBATING IN CEDA**

Brian R. McGee, Editor

For many years the CEDA debate community was differentiated in part from other debate-sponsoring intercollegiate organizations by its (alleged) commitment to non-policy debate topics and to value debate topics in particular. The topics used by CEDA for some two decades typically included no agent of action and avoided the verb “should,” though many of these topics made reference to a government or denounced a present or future course of action. Debate topics used in CEDA during the 1970s and 1980s illustrate this commitment to a reduced emphasis on the advocacy of specific policies by undergraduate debaters:

- Resolved: that American television has sacrificed quality for entertainment. (Spring 1975)
- Resolved: that activism in politics by religious groups harms the American political process. (Spring 1981)
- Resolved: that improved relations with the Soviet Union are a more important objective for the United States than increased military preparedness. (Fall 1986)

While members of the CEDA community recognized that policy discussions always were value-laden, the enthusiasm for value-centered topics created problems for students and coaches alike, as the community did not have established norms—let alone a theoretical apparatus—to guide in-round practice. The response to this problem was a sustained effort over the course of a decade to devise an appropriate theory or theories that would, in turn, influence practice. Beginning with a germinal essay by Ronald Matlon (1978, see Matlon, 1988), this effort at theory development included discussions of quasi-policy resolutions, pre-policy considerations, and policy implications, with the bulk of the relevant essays appearing in this journal, then known as the *CEDA Yearbook*. A few textbooks also were written with value debate in mind (e.g., Bartanen & Frank, 1991; Wilbanks & Church, 1991).

However, even as the theory of value debate (however defined) was becoming ever more sophisticated, in-round debate practice was increasingly blurring the already fuzzy distinction between value and policy debate. In the late 1980s many CEDA debaters and judges were rejecting the “value debate” framework, and plans and counterplans began to appear in CEDA debate rounds. By the mid 1990s the preference for policy topics had become obvious in the CEDA community, and the CEDA and NDT communities now share a common commitment to policy debate topics. Most recently CEDA members have chosen to remove non-policy topics from the topic ballot.

Given the community history, this forum brings together five well-known (I will not say senior) scholars who offer quite different perspectives on what some have described as CEDA’s experiment with value debate. **Michael Bartanen** addresses value debate by providing a systematic summary of the organizational and intellectual history of CEDA on this matter. **David M. Berube** bemoans the loss of value debate topics in CEDA and discusses the educational advantages of such topics. *Contra* Berube, **Dale A. Herbeck** and **John P. Katsulas** argue that the value-policy debate division has been overstated and see such divisions as posing substantive dangers for the larger debate community. Finally, **Linda M. Collier** grounds the discussion of value debate in the experience of students and judges in debate as practiced. Read together, these four essays provide fascinating insights on the recent past, the present, and (I suspect) the future of CEDA and intercollegiate debate.

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**CEDA'S EXPERIMENT WITH NON-POLICY PROPOSITIONS:
THE ROLE OF ORGANIZATIONAL AND CULTURAL INFLUENCES IN
SHAPING EDUCATIONAL CHOICES**

Michael Bartanen

The rise and fall of non-policy propositions in CEDA debate provide a useful case study of the relationship between theory and practice in academic debate and how systemic and cultural influences play a powerful role in shaping organizational decision-making. This essay addresses three questions: First, why was CEDA founded, and how can we account for its pragmatic decision to debate non-policy propositions? Second, how did systemic and cultural influences move the organization back to preferring policy propositions? Third, was the experiment with non-policy propositions a useful innovation in competitive debate?

The Southwest Cross-Examination Debate Association (SCEDA) was founded in 1971 by Jack Howe with the active assistance of other West and Rocky Mountain forensics directors. The organization had modest initial goals: to promote “communicative delivery, a balance among evidence, argument, and analysis, audience appeals and appropriate demands on students’ time and energy” (Louden & Austin, 1983, p. 7). For many years there was almost mythological belief that, from its inception, SCEDA (which eventually became CEDA) attempted to replace the National Debate Tournament. While the organization eventually outgrew the NDT in membership size and participation, the founders and early members believed that there was room in the forensic landscape for two organizations and that together they could serve the needs of students by providing multiple opportunities for students who, even thirty years ago, were facing growing financial and academic stresses that made it necessary for alternative debate formats.

From its creation, organizational choices in CEDA often were dictated by practical needs rather than responding to pedagogical needs identified through research and theory development. CEDA was, initially, a populist organization whose members had very significant input into organizational decisions unfiltered by governing boards. The National Parliamentary Debate Association (NPDA) is a current example of a large populist forensic

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organization. As a populist forensic organization, CEDA responded to member concerns through experimentation. In the context of the 1971 forensic world, CEDA was innovative. Four primary innovations are associated with CEDA: (1) use of the cross-examination format; (2) season-long school sweepstakes; (3) an eventual decision to use two topics per academic year; and (4) the eventual movement to the use of non-policy propositions. All of these ideas were well known prior to their adoption by CEDA. These innovations were chosen as part of an attempt to create an “audience-centered” alternative for students and programs. The cross-examination format appealed to audiences and non-traditional judges, as well as distinguishing CEDA from NDT debate, which did not, at that time, include cross-examination; the sweepstakes idea sought to level the playing field between large and small schools as well as making the contributions of novice students equal to those of senior division debaters; and use of two topics (with the first topic not being announced until September), was designed to help all students have a summer free of worrying about debate and giving debate opportunities to students who could not begin debating before January or novice students starting in the second quarter or semester. The final innovation was the use of non-policy propositions, which began in 1974. For nearly twenty years, the CEDA community consistently voted for non-policy propositions.¹ Policy propositions were occasionally listed on the topic ballot, but they rarely received much support.

Before noting some of the pragmatic reasons why CEDA used non-policy propositions, it is worth briefly discussing the role of debate propositions in forensic pedagogy. Does it matter whether students debate policy or non-policy propositions? The answer must be a qualified yes. The justification for academic debate cannot be simply grounded in teaching students policy analysis or research skills. As Bartanen (1994) observes, “debate is more than a game. It is a system of structured learning that engages students to learn how to put aside their prejudices in favor of beliefs based on ‘good reasons.’”(p. 98). Debate training must help students consider and test personal and societal values as well as teach students to consider the trade-offs of policy decisions. In a perfect world, there would not necessarily

¹ The term “non-policy propositions” is used intentionally here, rather than the term “value proposition.” There is dispute as to whether CEDA ever really debated strictly value propositions. Matlon (1988), Bartanen (1982), and Dixon and Leslie (1984) all criticize the assumption that typical resolutions were, strictly constructed, value propositions and ask whether CEDA debaters tended to debate those resolutions as policy or pseudo-policy resolutions regardless of the topic wordings.

be a clean dividing line between policy and non-policy debate. Debaters would be free to employ both policy and value arguments and assessment tools drawn from the widest range of disciplines, literally from art appreciation to medicine to political science to Zoroastrian thought. Whether fortunate or unfortunate, however, the debate proposition was originally introduced into debate to limit and narrow the focus of argument and resulting research and analysis burdens for debaters. The typology of a debate proposition tends to privilege a particular mind-set and limits the concomitant methodological and philosophical choices open to the advocate. While there are no rules preventing it, the systematic discussion of value issues in a policy debate round is unlikely, or at the very least, truncated.

It is unnecessary here to defend the importance of students learning to analyze and argue about values. Virtually all argumentation and debate scholars concur in the importance of that pedagogy. Yet despite widespread acceptance of the importance of debating value-based concepts, throughout its history the academic debate community has seemed to prefer to pursue the narrower path of focusing on policy issues. That makes CEDA's experience in both moving towards and then moving away from non-policy propositions relevant.

Why did CEDA experiment with non-policy propositions? The decision to do so reflected pragmatic needs rather than serving as an attempt to address the philosophical need to train student advocates in value-based analysis. There were, of course, calls by debate scholars for the debate community to consider debating non-policy propositions even before CEDA began the practice. It is difficult to cite evidence that, despite the clarity and significance of those calls, that philosophy alone explains CEDA's organizational choices. Instead, the reasons are found in the particular organizational challenges facing CEDA as a new forensics organization in the 1970s.

There are at least three pragmatically-grounded reasons why CEDA began debating non-policy propositions. First, non-policy propositions were believed to provide an opportunity for more communicative and audience-centered debates. This was a backlash to then-accepted practices in NDT debate that emphasized highly technical policy analysis, acceptance of rapid delivery and jargon, and significant student research burdens. The essence of the original CEDA philosophy was to restore the balance between research and delivery. Debating a non-policy proposition necessitated that students and teachers re-examine the premises of debate theory and practice. The non-policy proposition could, to an extent, free the debater from the supposed constraints of existing policy debate.

Second, using non-policy propositions strengthened the perceived distinctions between CEDA and NDT. In its early years and, to a degree throughout its institutional history, CEDA programs suffered from an inferiority complex when comparing themselves to major NDT programs. This inferiority was fostered in part by the reality that many of the early exclusively CEDA programs were smaller programs and ones which were, due to resource or philosophical objections, not major players in national circuit NDT debate. Despite their success and comfort in CEDA they did not perceive that they were really the equals of NDT programs. Rapidly, as CEDA began to expand, there was also a backlash by some NDT-oriented educators who rejected the premises of CEDA or who recognized and feared the substantial growth of the organization. Both proponents and opponents were anxious to clarify the bright lines distinguishing the two groups. The national policy debate topic has been a policy proposition since the 1920s. Choosing a non-policy proposition sent a very deliberate message distinguishing CEDA from NDT. Coincidentally or not, the rapid growth of CEDA came after the organization began to use non-policy topics. Conversely, Loudon (2001) suggests that the decision of NDT debate to use the CEDA topic was a prominent factor in the de facto reintegration of the two organizations.

Third, non-policy topics, combined with twice yearly topics, were an attempt to control the research burden and humanize forensics for both teachers and competitors. An explicit goal of CEDA in its early years was to provide a competitive opportunity which did not require students or teachers to spend extensive summer time researching and inventing arguments. A frequently expressed standard during topic writing meetings was to provide topic choices that would allow even students whose access was limited to marginal libraries to prepare sufficiently for debating the CEDA topic. Thus, topics needed to be drawn from issues covered in *Time* and other general news periodicals. While this may seem odd to a generation with Internet access to unlimited research resources, it was a crucial issue for many CEDA participants. Further, many of the early CEDA programs were attracted to the opportunity to competitively debate during only one of two semesters, or to include debaters who were unavailable (perhaps studying abroad) for one of the semesters. Needing two topics per year created particular difficulties for the organization. Having to create about 10 topics per year without excessively recycling topics was one challenge. Topic writing for most of CEDA's organizational history differed from the practices of NDT. I observed this process from both perspectives: serving as a member and chair of the Committee on Intercollegiate Discussion and Debate which, for many years, wrote policy topics while

simultaneously serving as a member of the CEDA topic selection committee. The processes could not be more different. Even as early as the 1980s, the CIDD commissioned topic analysis papers and met on multiple occasions to craft topic wordings. CEDA, on the other hand, would typically not meet during the summer (a practice which changed in the late 1980's) and would meet very briefly at the National Communication Association Convention. Fall topics during the early years were often discussed only by mail or through conversations with the Executive-Secretary. Spring topics were crafted hastily at meetings in a hotel room. Obviously, topic committee members (who were for many years elected by the membership from the Executive Council) thought about potential topic wordings. But without a doubt, topics would be written that would have benefited from more careful deliberation! On the other hand, the early CEDA topics were sometimes fresh and interesting, even if they were not ultimately selected. For example, prior to one election, a topic choice was: "Resolved that _____ should be elected President."

There was an active discussion of non-policy debate theory in debate literature and convention papers, and theory worked its way into debate rounds during the twenty years CEDA debated non-policy propositions. This very journal was upgraded from a collection of convention papers and articles into a regular, refereed publication. During the same period high schools began regularly debating non-policy propositions in Lincoln-Douglas debate, and, eventually, organizations such as NEDA, APDA (even prior to CEDA) and NPDA emerged using non-policy propositions and other vestiges of the early CEDA experiment. But despite an organization that maintained a reasonably stable population of subscribers; growing national influence; and, at best, a reduced core of committed NDT programs that provided the main alternative, the CEDA community eventually chose to move away from the core values, including using non-policy propositions, which facilitated the growth of the organization in the first place. It is appropriate to ask why.

I first begin with a brief discussion of the reasons I do not think explain the movement away from non-policy propositions. There was no particular failure in developing theories of non-policy debate. The intellectual discussion was vigorous; theoretical models were readily available; and the teachers working with CEDA debaters were active participants in the academic discussion. Others probably disagree with this assessment. But it is difficult to see where policy debate benefited from theoretical growth during the same period, which would support a claim that theory development was a significant factor in preferring policy to non-policy debate. Most substantial theoretical elements of policy debate, including

comparative advantage theory, paradigm development, and counter-plan theory, pre-dated CEDA's non-policy debate experiment or at least were reaching maturity during the same time period.

Instead, the reasons why CEDA moved back to the norm of using policy propositions (and simultaneously blurring all distinctions with NDT debate) is better understood through analyzing the systemic and cultural forces that influence intercollegiate forensics in all forms and at all levels (Bartanen, 1994). There are four general explanations for the movement away from using non-policy propositions.

First, forensics is, by its nature, inherently conservative. While obviously some elements of debate theory and practice are different, a debate judge active in the 1920's would find much in common watching a debate (using either the policy or parliamentary format) of the 2000's. The significant changes that have occurred in the last eighty years have been more at the margins than transformational. There are still eight speeches, policy stock issues, an understanding of decision-making criteria, and reliance on argument by authority. Other changes, such as various theoretical perspectives (e.g., counter-warrants or kritiks) come and go, and the core of debate remains constant. Without evidence I would even assert that rapid delivery, the bane of the CEDA founders, has also moved back in the direction of being more communicative. Thus, the history of the activity suggests that using non-policy propositions was outside the perceived acceptable margins of the debate activity and that it was likely inevitable that the forces pulling debate back to the perceived center would be stronger than the desire to innovate, particularly when, as noted earlier, the original decision to use non-policy propositions was a pragmatic rather than theory-driven decision.

Second, debate is strongly influenced by a growing preference for scientific rather than rhetorical paradigms of debate (Bartanen, 2002). Academic debate began as a rhetorically grounded activity. Early debate teachers were also often active as rhetorical scholars, and debate was defended as essential rhetorical training. In the post-World War II period this rhetorical model, which emphasized a balance between the rhetorical canons of invention and delivery, gradually gave ground to scientifically-based influences, paralleling similar shifts in the communication field generally. Prior to the end of the Second World War there was not an identifiable entity called communication theory. After 1945, communication theory, particularly those elements of theory emphasizing the use of quantitative research methods, became increasingly significant. Science-based communication theory has

certainly not eclipsed rhetorical theory, but there is preference for scientific-based theories in the mainstream of the communication discipline. A similar shift in emphasis is found in academic debate and is exemplified by growing interest, since the 1960s, in applying social science theory (for example, comparative advantages, or the hypothesis-testing paradigm). This trend reached its peak in the deliberations of the first National Developmental Conference on Forensics in 1975. The conference proceedings aligned forensics with scientific perspectives, most notably by defining forensics as a “laboratory experience,” (McBath, 1975, p. 9), the ultimate scientific metaphor.

To the degree that debate aligned itself with scientific models rather than the traditional rhetorical ones, the likelihood that the debate community would prefer policy to value propositions is apparent. Policy propositions lent themselves more easily to the application of quantitative data, the development of reasonably concrete decision-rules (e.g., comparing the quantitative impact of disadvantages to the quantitative advantage of the affirmative case), and dispassionate analysis of the effects of various policy scenarios. Analysis of non-policy propositions was not so neat. Comparing values, under the best of circumstances, is neither easy nor simple. This does not suggest that non-policy debate is more educationally challenging (although in my secret heart I think it might well be), but merely that to a debate and communication discipline increasingly grounded in empiricism, non-policy propositions posed an insurmountable puzzle: the debaters and teachers lacked the analytical tools to successfully discuss value issues. As Abraham Kaplan observes, “If the only tool you have is a hammer, you perceive every problem as requiring the pounding of a nail.” It is important to not go too far in condemning the scientific paradigm *per se*, but rather to indict scientific fundamentalism, and the assumptions that all questions can be reduced to the laws of physics, or quantified, or subjected to multiple regressions. Similarly, I would not want a robust rhetorical approach to debate to reject science or scientific thinking. Rather, the movements in debate have been between the two poles of specialization/scientific thinking/quantitative analysis and a leveling of authority, and adapting everything to an audience, regards of its knowledge and ability to reason. The best debate is integrative of various modes of thought.

The third systemic reason for preferring policy propositions is the growing importance of meeting the needs of “plug-and-play” debaters. The academic, financial and personal pressures on college students are substantial. The majority of contemporary college students have considerably less opportunity for or inclination to participate in discretionary uses of

their time than was true in the past. At the same time, one of the most important justifications of forensics programs is the attraction of very capable students, many of whom were successful high school debaters who sometimes choose a college based on financial or competitive opportunities provided by forensic programs. For many of these incoming students, the need to master a new set of stock issues and vocabulary must be balanced by the fact that participating in collegiate debate may take away from time and energy that could be devoted to being academically and socially successful in college. Why worry about sacrificing grades in order to learn to debate non-policy propositions when the only clearly tangible benefit is winning more trophies? Yet many programs rely on a steady influx of successful high school debaters to maintain their competitive strength. Unless there is a tangible benefit that is found in formats such as parliamentary debate, where there is a minimal on-going research burden, many experienced high school debaters choose not to continue debate in college. This became an additional pressure to make collegiate debate more like the prevalent policy-debate model of high schools.

The fourth and final reason was the domination of national circuit norms in influencing competitive practices. The death knell for non-policy propositions was probably sounded when the CEDA Executive Council, after considerable discussion, voted in 1985 to conclude the season with a national tournament.² The decision to host a national tournament had both intended and unintended consequences. One intended consequences was to formalize what had previously been an “informal” national championship tournament at the University of Nevada-Reno. Another goal of hosting a national championship was to provide greater visibility for CEDA and to acknowledge what organizational leaders of the time believed to be true: that CEDA debate was “legitimate” and that a true national championship tournament that would be open to all, rather than being available only to teams who met qualification standards, would meet both the on-going organizational goals of promoting a debate activity that encouraged both inclusion (by having a national and regional sweepstakes competition) and excellence, by crowning a single national champion.

One unintended consequence was to accelerate the growth of a national circuit mentality for CEDA. This perspective has always been an important element of NDT organizational culture. Teams aspiring for success at the NDT, for example, always knew they needed

² In the interests of full-disclosure it is important for me to acknowledge that I actively supported and lobbied for creation of a national CEDA tournament. I was also the first CEDA National tournament director in 1986.

national exposure at tournaments such as Georgetown, Northwestern, Wake Forest or Kansas. The at-large qualification system of the NDT encouraged and rewarded teams for successful participation in national circuit tournaments. Despite the lack of extrinsic reasons for a national circuit that were perceived as necessary in NDT debate, CEDA began to develop its own national circuit culture. The characteristics of the national circuit culture included a growing sense of being able to identify and copy strategies that the “good” teams were using, a growing consensus about judging and coaching standards necessary to identify the “best” team, and a narrowing of the tolerance for debate tactics that might be perceived as being outside the norm of what would be likely to win the national tournament.

The choice to have a national championship tournament, of course, was predictable. The national honoraries (DSR-TKA and PKD) began promoting “national championship” tournaments in the 1930s; the National Debate Tournament was initiated in 1947; and later, the National Forensic Association and the National Individual Events Tournaments were created. Having a single national champion is part of the conservative normative behavior of forensic organizations. This is not to suggest that crowning a national champion is necessarily bad. It does reinforce the systemic pressure on behavior that occurs when people perceive that the most important goal is being competitive in hopes of winning a national championship. This goal requires them to make choices that will maximize their chances of succeeding. In the case of CEDA, it added growing pressure to “standardize” debate practice so that competitors could know “exactly what it takes” to be nationally competitively successful. This meant reverting back to the norms of policy debate at the ultimate expense of debating non-policy propositions.

So what is the bottom line? Was the experiment with non-policy propositions a useful innovation in academic debate? At a philosophical level the experiment was an extremely valuable exercise in beginning the process of helping students confront complex, value-laden questions. While certainly some of these kinds of questions can be approached with the tools of science and policy-making, others are immune to judgment using scientific modes of thought. We have not taught some important skills of debate when we fail to create debate contexts that ask for qualitative judgments. For example, how are we to judge the religion of Islam without an understanding of how people are affected by the culture in which they read sacred texts, such as the Koran? How are we to debate the issue of the military tribunals and the trials of terrorists? How are we to debate the Israeli response to

Palestinian terrorism? All of these issues require modes of thought beyond or outside the realm of science as it is generally practiced in the West.

Was the experiment doomed from the start by organizational and cultural pressures? Is the debate community (particularly participants in the now size-dominant National Parliamentary Debate Association) preordained to live out the maxim that “those who do not attend to the lessons of history are doomed to relive them?” The answer is, probably, “all of the above.”

The experiment with non-policy propositions may illustrate the constant evolution of debate practice and the resilience of innovations such as non-policy debate. While CEDA moved away from non-policy debate, interest in alternatives to policy debate remains robust. The National Parliamentary Debate Association, and other organizations, regularly use non-policy propositions and retain the populist attitudes that characterized the founding and growth of CEDA. Perhaps parliamentary debate will eventually move back to debating policy propositions as well, or parliamentary debate might continue to grow and prosper as students and teachers realize the importance of balancing policy and non-policy debate skills.

On the other hand, the experiment may also show the systemic limits of debate as an educational tool. Perhaps it is unrealistic to expect too much from one activity and that the debate community must sacrifice the opportunities (and significant difficulties) provided by non-policy propositions with the benefits of sticking to the “tried and true” of policy debate.

There is no doubt that CEDA, including its twenty-year experiment with debating non-policy propositions, had a significant effect on the nature of intercollegiate debate. But it did not sustain its original vision or promise. Perhaps it never could do so. The array of countervailing pressures, including the conservative history of debate practice, the increasing dominance of science, the need to adapt to changing student needs, and the importance of national competition norms, when coupled with an experiment that began as an attempt to meet pragmatic rather than theoretical needs, leads to the conclusion that debating non-policy propositions was a noble, if doomed, experiment.

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A RADICAL COMPLAINT

David M. Berube

Non-policy debating, which was traditionally associated with the Cross-Examination Debate Association (CEDA), suffered a nearly terminal wound when CEDA reverted to year-long policy resolutions as an alternative on the topic ballots. Non-policy debating then died when National Debate Tournament (NDT) debating and CEDA merged, NDT decided to debate the CEDA topic, and CEDA kowtowed to fears and complaints regarding non-policy resolutions from both within and outside the CEDA community.

Nonetheless, in the United States non-policy topics remain viable and vibrant in the Lincoln-Douglas divisions in National Forensic League (NFL-LD) high-school and American Forensic Association collegiate Lincoln-Douglas (AFA-LD) competitive debating. Further, non-policy topics survived as motions in parliamentary debating in both the American Parliamentary Debate Association (APDA) and National Parliamentary Debate Association (NPDA), and in public debates, some of which are sponsored by the fledgling International Public Debate Association (IPDA). Non-policy topics are often used for on-campus public debates, political debate, and debates in the media as well. Outside the USA, they are used throughout the world as motions, especially associated with World's style parliamentary debating outside of Central and Eastern Europe. Of course, the pervasive use of non-policy resolutions demonstrates that these resolutions are debatable, and parliamentary debating has a healthy entry or novice division as well.

While it is true that many non-policy debates found in CEDA during the '80s were reduced to an examination of policy, that examination was one of many. The true difference between using a policy argument to prove a non-policy resolution probably true is that the policy or plan does not become a substitute resolution to the topic being debated. In policy debating parlance, parametric topicality is nothing more than a convention embraced by the debating community because it is more consistent with the competitive goals of the players. In policy debating, once the plan is topical (defined as representative of the topic wording), it becomes the focus of the debate and the nexus for both the affirmative and negative proofs. In addition, policy resolutions are written in the subjunctive mood and subsume the

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indicative generalizations that typify non-policy resolutions. As subjunctive generalizations, like policy resolutions, are built from instantiations, this suggests that indicative generalizations are already instantiations. If they are treated as universal instantiations, then they need to be examined as a totality (Berube 1991a, 1991b, 1994, 1995).

There are many reasons given for the demise of non-policy debating among colleges and universities that were members of CEDA a decade ago, but one of the reasons cannot be its incomprehensibility given that non-policy resolutions are used extensively in the United States and abroad. The disappearance of non-policy debate has more to do with the crowding-out effect of policy debating by colleges and universities mostly associated with NDT debate.

Prior to the “merger,” NDT policy debating was not well. The number of schools involved in the activity had dropped precipitously, and tournaments remained viable mostly due to schools fielding larger squads. Post-merger, the number of schools involved in CEDA debating has dropped significantly, though the CEDA programs that joined the NDT ranks invigorated the policy debate community. Schools dropping CEDA debate have either stopped fielding competitive debating program altogether or, more likely, have joined the parliamentary debate community. The switch to parliamentary debating probably has been accelerated by a number of debate faculty members who drop the activity upon securing tenure, leaving their host institution without the wherewithal to hire another faculty-line coach. While this situation is not unique to the last decade, the rise of parliamentary debate has given some institutions a debate alternative for which they may perceive that a debate coach with specific expertise is not necessary. It must be said here that some colleges and universities discount teaching, service, and especially scholarship associated with debating, and teachers with aspirations for promotion are pushed out or voluntarily elect to leave.

Though it is difficult to discern whether or not the parliamentary community would have grown without the transition to a year-long policy resolution in CEDA, it is not difficult to make a testable correlation. The cycle has begun anew.

Another reason debate has shifted from non-policy to policy resolutions has been the caliber of the coaching. Currently, graduate assistants and professional coaches, many without academic backgrounds in argumentation, do most collegiate coaching. Mostly, this is a function of economics in higher education caused by faculty dropping the activity upon securing tenure as mentioned above. At other times, the manager coach hires a former intercollegiate debater to coach the program and recruits a cadre of graduate assistants to cut

cards, to download Lexis-Nexis searches at tournaments, and to meet tournament judging obligations. Most debate teams have a corpus of standard argument types, typified by the politics disadvantage, which is run round after round. Some of the most successful programs are those with the largest budgets and, consequently, the largest number of graduate assistants researching the politics disadvantage.

The coaches in current policy debating could not find their way through an axiology, much less try to define what it is. Confronting the rigors of deconstructing a fact or a value frustrates most of them. The vast majority of our current policy coaches are policy wonk wannabes who see themselves as policy analysts when almost no one would seriously consider the variables that policy debate uses when making “real” policy. They delude themselves for a few years and move into a true career, in law or in business. Others hang on until they outlive their usefulness and without academic tenure to protect them, they are let out to pasture.

Without a basis in argumentation theory, non-policy resolutions appear foreboding for beginning and advanced debaters alike. These resolutions require that a debate team defend a methodology for deciding how the debate occurs (a metadebate) and a test that demonstrates the relative truth of the resolution (a debate). Policy debating seldom asks for that to occur, though there are two exceptions that must be mentioned.

First, critiques (kritiks) were born from non-policy debates where they were called value objections (criterial objections). Some NDT debaters and coaches found them and introduced this innovation to traditional policy debate. Some of these arguments ask the judge to evaluate the debate by an alternative methodology. This leads me to the second exception: a few policy debaters are performing for the ballot. The two versions of this involve the advocacy as a speech act of sorts and the construction of a challenging narrative or story. (Performance theorists remain appalled by the misapplication of theory there as well. Performing for a ballot is akin to turning a hurdy-gurdy for pocket change.)

These exceptions are especially intriguing since both are steps away from traditional policy debating towards non-policy debating. While at the same time the policy debate community has turned away from non-policy topics, they have turned towards non-policy arguments types in response to policy topics. What’s that all about?

In any event, the direction of the coaching is responsible in part for changing argument practice over time. On two levels, the change in this direction does not bode well for non-policy debating within CEDA. First, few people coach beginning debaters. By and large,

policy debating tournaments cannot be used as laboratories for classroom instruction. The jargon is alienating and artificial, and the parcel of generic argument forms frustrates inexperienced students. Policy debating is not necessarily the best format for teaching basic debating skills. Nonetheless, some coaches have made a career on coaching beginning debaters and have nearly won national team championships (or that is what they told college administrators) thanks to the egalitarian nature of the team award calculus.

Second, non-policy debating forces coaches to rethink a lot. Put simply, rethinking is not a forte among many of the policy coaches. New ideas in policy debating are discouraged. Experiments like Fort Hays State University's "project[s]" and the University of Louisville's "inter-media" arguments have been mostly frustrated. When they succeed, it is extraordinary and revolutionary rather than the standard occurrence.

Many members of the coaching world apparently would rather hear the same arguments over and over again and encourage their repetition despite false complaints to the contrary. It is not uncommon to hear a team being criticized by a critic for failing to argue a politics disadvantage as a component in their recipe of negative arguments. It is much easier to coach a program against the politics disadvantage year after year and topic after topic than it is to read topical literature to understand the principles associated with the claims being made.

Non-policy debating will live on, but it won't have a future in CEDA or NDT debating. Remaking CEDA as a body for non-policy debating would require that we offer exclusively non-policy debate topics on a ballot. CEDA would have to bite the bullet and lose some of the policy addicts. CEDA might also have to consider returning the two-topics-a-year option. This would increase entry opportunities and offer a buffer when a resolution is a dog. Though considering how poorly some of our topics have been worded recently, especially that one on Native Americans, we could hardly do worse than the status quo.

Realistically, the likelihood of a non-policy resolution on the ballot raises the hackles on the necks of traditional NDT coaches and debaters. The CEDA organization would need to take a mighty risky step to re-engage non-policy debating, but maybe it should before it becomes totally anachronistic. Currently, it hosts a national tournament, counts sweepstakes points, offers panels at some conventions and conferences, and hosts a topic meeting. For one, I do not think the courage resides in the current leadership to undertake this task. CEDA has shied from serious reform. As membership continues to shrink, its leaders have wrung their hands.

Instead, non-policy debate will live on in the currently alternative debate styles (e.g., NPDA, IPDA), though it seems that the community using parliamentary format and style already is larger than the policy community. Once parliamentary debating makes inroads in debate in high schools in America, especially with efforts by the English Speaking Union to introduce serious competitive debate for Worlds into the United States, policy debating on the college level will find fewer and fewer experienced debating students among incoming first-year debaters. “Worlds” competition may eclipse national circuits, which at last count have no less than eight different national championships and three separate rankings systems tracking the same competitors. The Oxford and Cambridge parliamentary style offers more prestige and a richer history. No fewer than seventy-five schools at NPDA Nationals in 2002 were former CEDA programs with only seventeen competing at both CEDA and NPDA Nationals in 2002.

The policy community will grow smaller and more incestuous until it returns to the state it was in during the mid- and late ‘80s.

Maybe it is time for CEDA to slip away, as its only roles seem to be keeping point records, hosting a topic committee process, and sponsoring a national tournament. If CEDA dies, NDT will host the topic meetings, and someone will continue to host large end-of-the-year tournaments. Maybe it is time for policy debating to slip away entirely; extinction may not be so bad. Life and debating will go on in some form or another. For one, I believe I could sleep quite well knowing that I would never need to decide whether Bush’s focus is limited or bipartisanship is being wasted.

Nothing said above is meant to suggest that this author is guiltless, and, as I have never shirked from speaking my mind, here are my concluding remarks.

As a competitive debate coach at a university that has traditionally debated in policy debating since the middle of the twentieth century, we debate what we can and at least in the immediate future that remains policy debating. However, after three decades of participation in policy and non-policy debating, I predict that parliamentary debating will do to CEDA and NDT debating what CEDA did to NDT debating in the 1980s. Simply put, policy debating is an elitist activity with conventions that favor programs with the largest budgets and the deepest staffs. As more and more schools discover they are fodder for others, they will quit the activity entirely and move into parliamentary format debating that reinforces critical thinking, strong speaking, and creative argument.

Finally, CEDA and NDT may lose more and more students who have other interests, want to emphasize their academic studies, and believe debating should be more fun. Cutting politics cards all-night and debating all day at tournaments simply is not what many of us signed on to do, especially those of us who are substance-free and do not have a cadre of card-cutting, slave-waged, under-appreciated, unemployed, and unregistered former debaters, fifth year (or more) undergraduates, and graduate students. Non-policy debating with resolutions rotating semester-to-semester, month-to-month, tournament-to-tournament, and round-to-round may offer an equalizer.

Maybe, it's time to take a step back to a time when an alternative to policy debating that was not evidence-free flourished. While colleagues balk at parliamentary debate without evidence, they might be better accommodated by a style without tired policy resolutions but maintaining a more demanding standard of proof and evidence. This task belongs to the current CEDA leadership because the next generation of leaders may discover it's simply too late.

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REFLECTIONS ON THE DEATH OF VALUE RESOLUTIONS

Dale A. Herbeck and John P. Katsulas

This essay is grounded in experience. As undergraduates, we debated during the early years of the Cross Examination Debate Association (CEDA). While we traveled the National Debate Tournament (NDT) circuit, we were keenly aware that there was considerable dissatisfaction with the state of intercollegiate debate. By the time we entered graduate school, the debate community had split into two warring factions. While NDT remained strong, CEDA started a national tournament and a growing number of schools switched to value debate. Over time CEDA membership surpassed NDT membership, and CEDA Nationals became the largest debate tournament in the country. A strong core of schools remained committed to NDT, however, and eventually the leadership of the two organizations wisely arrived at the decision to debate a common policy resolution. While loyalty to NDT and CEDA remains strong in some circles, a growing number of teams freely transverse the borders bounding these organizations.

This brief essay does not attempt to summarize that history, nor does it seek to contribute to the significant body of literature on value debate theory and practice. Rather, we wish to posit three simple, yet controversial claims: first, the purported distinction between value and policy debate was exaggerated; second, contrary to the broader title of this forum, intercollegiate debate still considers value issues; and, finally, the future of intercollegiate debate may well hinge on our ability to learn from the value debate experience.

A Distinction Without a Difference

The distinction between policy and value debate has consistently been overstated. No doubt, this is partially due to the fact that one of the easiest ways to explain the difference between CEDA and NDT was to distinguish between the types of resolution being debated. CEDA debated values whereas NDT debated policy, and that seemed sufficient to legitimate two different organizations, two different travel schedules, and two different national champions. The debate literature of this era took this distinction quite seriously, as is

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evidenced by the impressive body of work focusing on the nature of value resolutions and discussing how value resolutions should be debated.

While our scholarship established that resolutions matter, in retrospect it is obvious that these theoretical distinctions tended to obscure the larger issues that led to the original split within the debate community. It is important to observe that CEDA debated value resolutions, but it is more important to note that CEDA debated those resolutions in a different way. As the organization's title implied, CEDA featured cross-examination in all debates. Although it now seems implausible, we can remember debating at NDT tournaments without cross-examination, at tournaments where cross-examination started in elimination rounds, or at tournaments where cross-examination time came out of prep time. While NDT quickly embraced cross-examination, CEDA was still different as CEDA schools switched resolutions midway through the year. At the same time, CEDA also stressed delivery and style, and this emphasis was evident in competitive practice.

Over time, the distinctions between CEDA and NDT began to disappear. While everyone always suspected that this was the case, it was dramatically proven when both organizations began debating a common policy topic. Almost from the outset, debaters were able to cross organizational boundaries with considerable competitive success. CEDA teams began to attend NDT tournaments, and NDT teams began to travel to CEDA competitions. While allegiance to both organizations remains strong, it is increasingly difficult to explain the differences between CEDA and NDT debate. The best debaters have repeatedly demonstrated that they can succeed on either circuit.

Having come this far, it now appears clear the significance of debating value resolutions was exaggerated. While our scholarship carefully delineated the difference between value and policy resolutions and what that meant for debate practice, it would be misleading to suggest that the desire to debate value questions alone led to the creation of CEDA. At the same time, it would be equally misleading to suggest that dissatisfaction with value debate led to the decision to debate a common national resolution. The difference between value and policy resolutions made it easy to distinguish CEDA from NDT, but it never fully explained the broader forces that led our community to divide into two separate organizations.

The Death of Value Debate is Exaggerated

It was inevitable, therefore, that pressure began to build for a common resolution. From an economic perspective, it made no sense for NDT and CEDA to maintain separate

tournament schedules. Boston College drove past the United States Military Academy at West Point, New York, en route to the United States Naval Academy at Annapolis, Maryland. We routinely debated against Dartmouth and Harvard, but never against Cornell, Rochester or Vermont. As travel costs increased and participation dwindled, it made good sense to revisit the wisdom of debating different resolutions. The resulting decision to select a single resolution had the practical result of creating a common schedule. As a result, it lowered travel costs, it increased the quality of competition, and it strengthened our community.

At the same time, it is also true that many within our community had come to prefer debating policy questions. Although CEDA debated some timely questions, debaters had trouble conceptualizing and arguing many of these value resolutions. Almost from the outset, policy arguments like disadvantages began to appear in value debate. Plans and counterplans became increasingly common in the 1980s, and CEDA eventually chose to remove non-policy questions from the ballot altogether. It would, however, be a mistake to conclude that our community has repudiated value questions. While CEDA and NDT have decided to debate a shared policy resolution, values remain at the heart of contemporary intercollegiate debate. What has changed is the way in which those issues are debated. Instead of debating value resolutions, it has become common practice to attack the values underlying policy positions.

This was particularly true during the 2001-2002 academic year when the resolution required the federal government to increase control over Indian country. Although this resolution was phrased as a policy question, most debates considered the broader issue of whether it was desirable to increase government control over the affairs of Native Americans. One of the most common negative arguments asserted that state control necessarily violated the inherent rights of Native Americans to manage their own affairs. Increased state control, it was argued, was bad policy because it violated important cultural values. We still debate values, although we do so in a policy context.

Reflections on the Value Debate Experience

The forensic community has always been threatened by internal division, and this is proven by our experience with value resolutions. While substantive concerns led to the formation of CEDA, the bitter split that resulted was larger than the issues warranted. Even as the differences between CEDA and NDT are fading into forensics lore, we are

confronting entirely new challenges in the form of Lincoln-Douglas (LD) debate, the National Parliamentary Debate Association (NPDA), and the National Educational Debate Association (NEDA).

At face value, debate is good and we should do everything that we can to increase the opportunity for students to participate in this educational activity. LD is flourishing, especially at the high school level where it introduced thousands of students to competitive debate. So too, the growth of parliamentary debate at the collegiate level has lowered the formidable entry barriers to competition. Schools without large travel budgets or professional coaches have learned that they compete with success on the parliamentary playing field. Along the same lines, NEDA has created a unique space for schools agreeing to abide by a common set of rules governing debate practice.

Under closer examination, however, there is real reason to worry about the overall health of intercollegiate debate. While more students may be involved in debate, the danger is that we may be dividing ourselves into progressively smaller organizations. As our community fragments, we risk marginalizing ourselves and trivializing our educational objectives. Our collective experience with value resolutions is instructive as it warns us that we should not lose sight of our broader aspirations. There may have been legitimate reasons for debating value resolutions, but there was no reason to allow our community to divide into hostile factions.

This forum is timely because it invites us to consider the larger questions. While we believe that the historical significance of value resolutions was exaggerated, we also believe that our community is better for having argued these questions. There can be little doubt but that the opportunity to argue value resolutions had a profound influence on contemporary debate practice. At the same time, we also believe that we are a stronger community because CEDA and NDT now share a common topic. As we look to the future, we hope that forensic educators will be able to draw an important lesson from the value debate experience. We should not hesitate to consider difficult questions or to challenge convention, but we should be wary of creating contested borders that segment our community.

Q: “WHATEVER HAPPENED TO VALUE DEBATE...IN CEDA?”
A: IT’S BEING MISAPPLIED ON POLICY TOPICS
(AND WHY I DON’T LIKE IT)

Linda M. Collier

The invitation to write in this forum posed the following questions designed to explore the relative merits of the CEDA experiment with non-policy debate:

- Was it a mistake?
- Why was it derailed?
- How does Lincoln-Douglas (LD) debate relate, if at all?
- Was the rejection the result of a poorly developed theoretical framework?
- Should we return to some mix of policy/non-policy topics?
- Were non-policy topics more difficult for beginners to comprehend?

I will answer those questions, but a prologue to make my claim that value debate is being misapplied should make that claim more understandable.

I came to CEDA in 1986 from practicing law. Cross-examination was familiar, but “non-policy or value” was completely unknown to me as competitive debate because Lincoln-Douglas debate developed after I graduated from high school, and my college debate experience was exclusively in the traditional policy format.

Speaking with people in the debate community in 1986 about the world I was entering, I was told that during the debates values were compared, objections were raised and topicality was still debated even though there was no plan. I asked how a judge determined who won or lost and was told it depended on the round. This was my first introduction to the emerging concept of criteria.

I believe that now, like then (1986-1995), intercollegiate debate is constantly evolving, and the topic itself has very little to do with what is being debated and how the debates are occurring. I contend that the biggest differences under the competitive academic debate

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umbrella¹ are differences of process and have little or nothing to do with the resolution or how it is characterized. Why? Because the object of all of the debate activities is *to win*. That's the commonplace. All of these activities are based on team v. team with the intention of declaring a winner and, hence, a loser at the end of each contest. The goal is not to discover the truth, find a compromise, or even decide an issue within the forum. That's one reason debate is both a great exercise in learning and why it simultaneously distorts learning, especially concerning (how ironic) life's values. It rewards participants immediately for their efforts, but it does so in a completely artificial setting—no life or property or freedom is actually on the line like in a courtroom, for example.

That winning isn't everything--it's the *only* thing--is why debaters "in the then" used policy approaches on non-policy topics and debaters "in the now" are using non-policy approaches on policy topics. There's nothing wrong with that, and there's nothing really surprising about it, but that doesn't mean I (or you) have to like it, reward it, admire it, and/or advocate it. Community practice leaves it up to the individual with the ballot in each contest.

Community discussion on the e-debate list serve in March, 2002, indicated that non-traditional/value approaches were successful on the 2002 topic, and were being strategically used to cause opponents to drop or mishandle arguments. In other words, "critical" teams were winning not because of persuasive rhetoric or arguments, but because they could beat opponents with the traditional rubric for debate decision making, including time constraints, speaking order, drops become concessions, no new arguments, etc.

In my opinion the arguments and performances are made to create space for a "w," otherwise debaters would be activists, not college debaters. I agree that investigating the underlying assumptions of our current political state and learning to advocate the discursive implications of language choice are interesting and potentially helpful. I absolutely believe in free expression, but I also think that almost every debate argument is made for the purpose of winning. The bottom line is that, from my (granted) semi-external perspective, debaters do what they do because they like it and/or because it makes them successful.

¹ The "debate umbrella" includes Lincoln-Douglas debate, with two competing advocates; traditional team debate, with two-person teams competing against one another; and parliamentary debate, with teams who compete against one another while using different evidentiary and advocacy conventions than those used in traditional team debate.

I hear debaters violate the rhetorical principles they advocate in rounds and express completely hypocritical positions in subsequent rounds. That is all okay because, until recently, the activities of debate rounds were perceived as the products of a specialized forum and laboratory in which thoughts, ideas, logical schemes, assumptions and other conceits and concepts were explored, tested and performed with the community understanding that these events are done ethically, but *to win*. That is why value debate shifted to policy debate, and that is why the alter-policy acts and arguments are being made today. This isn't hard.

Now to the specific questions I was invited to answer about the relative merits of the CEDA experiment with non-policy debate.

The Forum

Was it a mistake? No.

Why was it derailed? See above and below.

How does LD relate, if at all? Very little. High school LD debaters have difficulty making the transition to working with a partner and, hence, rarely if ever do policy debate in college. Because debaters currently drive the activity as much or more than coaches, there is very little opportunity for LD to have influence in college team debate in terms of in-round practice and argument selection.²

Was the rejection the result of a poorly developed theoretical framework? No. It just became easier to win in a non-traditional (in this instance policy) format when the anger against "NDT-type" (i.e., faster, policy) debate was diluted as new critics and debaters entered the CEDA world. I wasn't part of college debate when CEDA and NDT were purposely separated, but, according to hearsay, there was deep animosity on both sides of the split that colored *many* of the decisions the two communities made. In effect, policy-focused debate played the same role in CEDA in 1987-1995 that value (i.e., critical) debate plays today, and when the space for critiques in policy debate coalesced with the diminution of the NDT and the 1997 topic merger with CEDA, non-policy debate became unnecessary.

² Some foolishly believe that "value debate" is easier or requires less research and preparation. Actually neither is true, but creating a distinction between the two activities allows a separation of participants that creates the chance for more people to "specialize" and thus create more "winning" opportunities for more people.

Should we return to some mix of policy/non-policy topics? Okay...or not. I happen to prefer policy, but I'd just like to hear the *topic debated*. Until it is, we as a community will continue to vote for topics based on perceived subject matter rather than on the wording, which exacerbates the reasons topicality is not an effective mechanism to equalize ground and other perennial problems.

What does debating the topic mean? If it is a policy topic,³ use the acknowledged political argumentative contexts. The reason solvency and advantages against disadvantages and alternative actors/actions is used is because that's how Western, Cartesian-based thinkers assess things. Tibetan debate, for example, is completely different, and the concept of winning is more about pleasing the other than winning the endorsement of a third party (Perdue, 1976/1980). For multiple, complex reasons this essay won't question, English-speaking individuals in the world of academic debate have chosen to use a statement of particular words in an allegedly grammatical framework to state the resolution. As long as an allegedly neutral third party is assigned to decide who wins a debate (rather than the debaters), and/or we learn how to read minds, grammar and other western influences will continue to shape how the most predictable *winning* strategy is constructed. From my perspective, the nominal policy⁴ approach on a policy topic is more likely to succeed.

Were non-policy topics more difficult for beginners to comprehend? Yes, because high school debaters came out of a policy world in high school. A large influx of LD debaters to team value debate will never happen. See above.

Coda

Debate is a wonderful enhancement to education. I encourage each reader to work for all debate styles and fora that appeal to them. That's my call to action with the following cautionary epilogue.

First, everyone needs to come to grips with the fact that debate rounds look and sound completely different to those debating than to most judges. Ask any debater who has recently moved from the front of the room to the back of the room. Former debaters have related to me their epiphanic experiences when they realize that with few exceptions, the

³ I define a policy topic as one that questions whether an entity ought to act differently in the future.

⁴ See n. 3, above.

people with ballots evaluate the debate far more simply than the debaters in the round do. A recent spirited e-debate exchange in which coaches lamented the absence of questioning or exploring or arguing about the quality/source of evidence read in rounds is a good example of the unnecessary hyper-complication which debaters undertake. Instead of taking advantage of the illogic or lack of warrants in evidence, debaters read two bad cards to answer the first card rather than just pointing out the problems with the original evidence. That unnecessarily complicates the debate, because it gives some level of credibility to the bad first argument rather than eliminating it as a bad argument. That doesn't make the debate worthless, just less enjoyable to judge. And hey, to secure a *win*, the real goal of a debater should be to make the round enjoyable for the judge!

Second, everyone with a ballot who *accurately* discloses her or his preferences is a good judge, and each judge has preferences. Debaters who want to win should attempt to satisfy the expectations of the judges, and we judges need to take charge of the round. Cate Palchewski is a good example of someone who makes her expectations clear—you know what is acceptable to her and what is not.⁵

⁵ In the spirit of full disclosure, here's what I wrote as a footnote in the description of me as a debate judge:

I dislike the application of critical arguments to policy debate resolutions. I find them out of place, especially because I started out in CEDA as it evolved through the "value debate" model back to policy. As it matured, CEDA value debate became policy oriented-- "life/survival" became the only successful terminal value, the "case" became the focus of the debate, not the resolution, and when the resolutions changed, policy mechanics like disadvantages and counter plans replaced value objections and counter warrants. CEDA voted for quasi-policy resolutions without the word should, and finally completed the transition in the mid-90's. Why did that happen? Because debaters discovered that plan and advantages vs. the counter plan and disadvantages "formula" produces the most consistent, predictable outcome within the existing forum of intercollegiate debate. I believe that is true today. Until we adopt a non-policy resolution (not something I'm rooting for) or substantially change the format of intercollegiate debate it will be hard to convince me to embrace critical arguments.

Whether value or policy or something in between, debate is good when it encourages people to stretch their reasoning capacity. In this world of mutual judge preference, multiple interpretations of the values and policies contained in topics will continue as long as such interpretations entertain and reward students and their coaches.

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